



PHOTO BY RAJWANT RAWAT

CUSTOMER FIRST IndiGo CEO Pieter Elbers says airlines should treat customers well and enable employees to do a great job of running a safe and reliable operation

of India's size, population, ambition and economic drive, there should be more than one airline. I find many of the questions to me are focussed on how we are going to compete with the Tatas. I could almost reverse it and say, how can Indian carriers collectively get back their market share on international routes? That would be a very interesting proposition.

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You are scheduled to take deliveries of Airbus 321 XLRs by 2024. How do you propose to deploy them?

Today, all our international routes are within a certain range determined by the Airbus 321. The XLR will expand that range by enabling us to add destinations that are further off. Of course, one could look to Europe, but one could also look at Asia, or more precisely, South-East Asia.

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So, when are we going to see IndiGo launching

ultra-long-haul flights to destinations such as the US and Australia?

We haven't decided on that as we are keeping all options open. Meanwhile, we will continue to develop our network, and when the time is ripe, [we will] take a decision.

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Despite having many firsts to its credit, how come IndiGo doesn't have a loyalty programme to date?

There is a Ka-ching card, which is a loyalty programme. We have people from our loyal customer base flying for work or holiday. It's time to further build on that base. But are we considering more for the future? Yes, we are! Have we taken a final decision on how precisely we are doing to do that? No, we haven't! **BT**

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The writer was in Ras Al-Khaimah at the invitation of IndiGo

yields have risen more than the ATF prices."

A welcome development is the dismantling of the pricing caps on airfares in August, a legacy of Covid-19. "This will help airlines sustain with better PLFs (passenger load factors). We have witnessed a strong recovery this summer holiday season and we expect the trend to continue through the festive season as well," says Kumar. Adds Jasani: "Air fares have increased sharply on the busier routes over the past few months, which helps the company to boost revenues."

T Gangwal announced his exit from InterGlobe Aviation's Board following a three-year dispute. IndiGo also witnessed a semblance of industrial unrest after a large section of pilots, cabin crew and technicians proceeded on go-slow, demanding withdrawal of pay cuts announced in 2020 to manage falling revenues during Covid-19. After this severely affected IndiGo's on-time performance, the airline restored full pay of employees in tranches.

Another weak area for the airline is customer service. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation recently levied a ₹5-lakh fine on the airline for barring a child with special needs from boarding a flight from Ranchi. In late 2017, some ground staff members were sacked after they were recorded beating up a passenger on the tarmac at Delhi airport. "IndiGo, while efficient, has become arrogant and is no longer a much-loved airline. With competition snapping at its heels, passengers have a chance to choose from among its competitors," says Gopinath.

Elbers says he is committed to changing that. "Even if you have a high market share but your service does not match that, your product is not on time and if passengers don't feel happy, you will start losing that automatically. It is our ambition, drive and commitment to our customers to continue to deliver an excellent service," he says.

Good intentions, but it will take more than that to surmount IndiGo's challenges. **BT**

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With inputs from Rahul Oberoi